“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 5

Rāmānanda Rāya Instructs Pradyumna Miśra

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Bitten by the worm of ripening karma and afflicted by the sore of malice, I, sunk in an ocean of humility, take shelter of Caitanya, the physician.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the son of Śacī! Glory, glory to the all-merciful, blessed Nityānanda!

3 Glory to Advaita, the ocean of mercy! Glory to all the devotees! Glory to Svarūpa, Gadādhara, Rūpa and Sanātana!

4 One day Pradyumna Miśra bowed down at the Lord’s feet and humbly made a request.

5 “Hear me, O Lord: I am a wretched, lowly householder. By what fortune have I obtained Your feet, so rarely attained?

6 I wish to hear talks about Kṛṣṇa. Be kind to me and tell me about Kṛṣṇa.”

7 The Lord said, “I do not know talks about Kṛṣṇa. Only Rāmānanda knows them; I hear them from his lips.

8 It is your good fortune that your mind longs to hear about Kṛṣṇa. Go to Rāmānanda and hear from him.

9 You have a taste for talks about Kṛṣṇa — you are very fortunate. One who has a taste for talks about Kṛṣṇa is truly fortunate."

10 "The *dharma* a person performs, however well, is certainly nothing but wasted labor if it does not awaken attraction (*rati*) for the narrations about Viṣvaksena, the Lord." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.8)

11 Then Pradyumna Miśra went to Rāmānanda's house, and Rāya's servant offered him a seat.

12 Not finding Rāya there, he asked the servant, and the servant told him what Rāya was doing:

13 "There are two *deva-kanyā*s, maidens dedicated to the service of the Deity, supremely beautiful, very skilled in dance and song, and in their early youth.

14 Rāya has taken them both to a secluded garden and is teaching them to dance to the songs of his own drama.

15 Please sit here and wait; he will come shortly. Whatever you ask of him, he will do."

16 So Pradyumna Miśra stayed there, waiting, while Rāmānanda was in a secluded place with the two maidens.

17 With his own hands he anointed them with oil; with his own hands he bathed them and cleansed their bodies.

18 With his own hands he dressed them and adorned every limb, and yet the mind of Rāya Rāmānanda remained unmoved.

19 As one feels when touching wood or stone, so is Rāmānanda's nature when he touches a young woman.

20 Regarding them as the ones to be served (*sevya-buddhi*), he serves them, and he takes upon himself his own natural mood of a maidservant.

21 The glory of Mahāprabhu's devotees is unfathomable, and among them Rāmānanda is the utmost limit of *bhāva*, *bhakti* and *prema*.

22 Then he taught the two to dance and had them act out the hidden meaning of the songs.

23 Through acting with the face and eyes they made manifest the signs of the transitory (*sañcārī*), the *sāttvika* and the abiding (*sthāyi*) emotions.

24 The graceful dance that reveals *bhāva*, which Rāya teaches them, the two display openly before Jagannātha.

25 Then he fed the two *prasāda* and quietly sent them home.

26 Every day Rāya trained them in this way. What petty soul can know where his mind dwells?

27 The servant told Rāya that Miśra had come, and Rāmānanda at once came to the hall.

28 Showing him respect, he bowed to Miśra and humbly said:

29 “You came long ago, and no one told me. I have committed an offense at your feet.

30 Your coming has purified my home. Command me — what shall I, your servant, do?”

31 Miśra said, “I came to see you, and by seeing you I have purified myself.”

32 Seeing that it was too late, Miśra said nothing more; he took his leave and went home.

33 The next day Miśra came before the Lord, and the Lord asked, “Did you hear about Kṛṣṇa from Rāya?”

34 Then Miśra told Him what Rāmānanda had been doing, and when Mahāprabhu heard it, He began to speak.

35–36 “I am a *sannyāsī* and consider Myself detached; yet, to say nothing of seeing a woman, if I merely hear a woman’s name, My body and mind are disturbed. Who can remain steady on seeing a woman?

37 Hear, all of you, about Rāmānanda Rāya — an account so wondrous that it can hardly be told.

38 First, they are *devadāsī*s, maidservants of the Deity, and moreover they are beautiful young women; yet he himself performs every service for them.

39 He bathes them, dresses them in clothes and ornaments, and sees and touches all the private parts of their bodies.

40 Yet the mind of Rāya Rāmānanda remains unmoved as he teaches them to express the rising of many different *bhāva*s.

41 His body and mind are unmoved, like wood or stone. How wonderful — at the touch of a young woman his mind is unmoved!

42 Rāmānanda alone has this qualification; from it I know that his body is transcendental.

43 Only he knows the state of his mind; there is no one else fit to know it.

44 But in the light of scripture I draw one inference, and the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* bears witness to it.

45–46 Whoever, with faith, tells of or hears about Kṛṣṇa's *rāsa* dance and other pastimes with the young women of Vraja — his lust, the disease of the heart, is destroyed at once. The three *guṇas* no longer agitate him, and he becomes 'deeply sober' (*mahā-dhīra*).

47 He attains *prema-bhakti* in the radiant *madhura-rasa* and always sports in bliss in Kṛṣṇa's sweetness.

48 "One who, endowed with faith, constantly hears about this play of Viṣṇu with the young women of Vraja and then describes it, soon attains supreme devotion to the Lord and, becoming sober, quickly casts off lust, the disease of the heart." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.33.39)

49 Whoever hears it or reads it gains such a fruit. And one who serves day and night is absorbed in *bhāva*;

50 what can I say of his fruit? It cannot be put into words. He is eternally perfect (*nitya-siddha*), and his body is almost perfect (*prāya-siddha*).

51 I know that Rāya worships on the path of *rāgānuga*. His body is like a perfected body (*siddha-deha*), and so his mind is not mundane.

52 I too hear about Kṛṣṇa from Rāya. If you wish to hear, go there again.

53 Tell him in My name: ‘He has sent me to hear about Kṛṣṇa from you.’

54 Go quickly, while he is still in the hall.” Hearing this, Pradyumna Miśra set off in haste.

55 He went to Rāya, and Rāya bowed to him and said, “Command me; tell me why you have come.”

56 Miśra said, “Mahāprabhu has sent me to hear about Kṛṣṇa from you.”

57 Hearing this, Rāmānanda was pleased at heart, and with joy in his heart he said:

58 “By the Lord’s order you have come here to hear about Kṛṣṇa. Where else could I find such great fortune?”

59 Saying this, he took him to a secluded place, sat down with him and asked Miśra, “What would you like to hear?”

60 He said, “What you told in Vidyānagara — please tell me those things, in their order.

61 What to speak of others — you are the instructor of the Lord! I am only a mendicant *brāhmaṇa*, and you are my sustainer.

62 Good or bad, I do not know how to ask anything. Seeing how wretched I am, be merciful and tell me yourself.”

63 Then Rāmānanda began to speak, step by step, and the ocean of the nectar of *rasa* in talks about Kṛṣṇa surged up.

64 He himself raised the questions and then gave the conclusions. The third watch (*prahara*) of the day came, and still the talk did not end.

65 Speaker and listener, one speaking and the other hearing, were both absorbed in *prema*. They had no awareness of themselves — how could they know the day had ended?

66 When the servant said, “The day is over,” Rāya brought the talk about Kṛṣṇa to a pause.

67 With great respect he bade Miśra farewell, and Miśra, crying, “My life is fulfilled!” began to dance.

68 Miśra went home, bathed and took his meal, and in the evening he came to see the Lord’s feet.

69 With a joyful heart he bowed at the Lord’s feet, and the Lord asked, “Did you hear about Kṛṣṇa?”

70 Miśra said, “O Lord, You have fulfilled my life! You have plunged me into the ocean of the nectar of talks about Kṛṣṇa.

71 The words of Rāmānanda Rāya cannot be retold. Rāya is not a mere human being; he is made of the *rasa* of devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

72 Rāya told me one thing more: ‘Do not think of me as the speaker of these talks about Kṛṣṇa.

73 Gauracandra Himself speaks these words through my mouth. As He makes me speak, so I speak, like a *vīṇā*.

74 Through my mouth He makes these words known. Who in this world will understand this pastime of His?’

75 All that I heard — that Kṛṣṇa is the ocean of *rasa* — lies beyond the reach even of Brahmā and the other gods.

76 You have made me drink such *rasa*; birth after birth I have sold myself at Your feet.”

77 The Lord said, “Rāmānanda is a mine of humility. He takes his own words and places them on another’s head.

78 This is the natural disposition of great souls: they never speak of their own qualities.”

79 Thus I have told a trace of Rāmānanda Rāya’s qualities: how he instructed Pradyumna Miśra.

80 Though a householder, Rāya is not under the control of the six enemies (*ṣaḍ-varga*); though seemingly a worldly man (*viṣayī*), he instructs *sannyāsīs*.

81 To reveal all these qualities of his, the Lord sent Miśra there to hear.

82 The Lord knows well how to reveal the qualities of His devotees; revealing them in various ways, He considers it His own gain.

83 Hear, O devotees, of yet another trait of Gaura: He makes His hidden, majestic nature manifest.

84 To destroy the pride of the *sannyāsīs* and *paṇḍitas*, He makes *dharma* manifest through a lowly *śūdra*.

85 He speaks of *bhakti*, *prema* and *tattva*, making Rāya the speaker, while He Himself, together with Pradyumna Miśra, becomes the listener.

86 Through Haridāsa He revealed the glory of the holy name; through Sanātana, the play of the conclusions of *bhakti*.

87 Through Śrī Rūpa He revealed Vraja's pastimes of *rasa* and *prema*. Who can describe the profound play of Caitanya?

88 These pastimes of Śrī Caitanya are an ocean of nectar, a single drop of which can flood the world.

89 Drink the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* constantly, for from it come the bliss of *prema* and knowledge of the truth of *bhakti*.

90 In this way Mahāprabhu, together with His devotees, enjoyed His pastimes in Nīlācala, preaching *bhakti*.

91 A brāhmaṇa from Bengal composed a drama on the Lord's life and came, bringing it to recite.

92 He was acquainted with Bhagavān Ācārya; having met him, he took lodging in his house.

93 First he recited the drama to him, and many Vaiṣṇavas heard it along with him.

94 Everyone praised the drama as "most excellent," and all wished to have Mahāprabhu hear it.

95 Whatever song, verse, book or poem anyone composed and brought, he would first recite it before Svarūpa.

96 If it passed before Svarūpa and his mind accepted it, only then would it be recited for Mahāprabhu to hear.

97 If there was *rasābhāsa*, a mere semblance of *rasa*, or anything opposed to *siddhānta*, the Lord could not bear it, and anger arose in His mind.

98 Therefore the Lord would not hear anything first; He had made this rule of propriety a fixed principle.

99 Bhagavān Ācārya made a request to Svarūpa: “A brāhmaṇa has composed an excellent drama about the Lord.

100 First you hear it, if your mind accepts it; afterwards I shall have Mahāprabhu hear it.”

101 Svarūpa said, “You are a ‘cowherd’ (*gopa*), most generous: a desire arises in you to hear any scripture whatever.

102 In the words of just any poet there is *rasābhāsa*, and hearing what is opposed to *siddhānta* brings no joy.

103 One who cannot discriminate between *rasa* and *rasābhāsa* never reaches the far shore of the ocean of *bhakti-siddhānta*.

104–105 One who knows neither grammar nor rhetoric and has no knowledge of the ornaments of drama — such a worthless one does not know how to describe Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes, and this play of Caitanya is especially hard to approach.

106 Only one for whom the lotus feet of Gaura are the very wealth of life can describe the pastimes of Kṛṣṇa and the pastimes of Gaura.

107 To hear the poetry of a mundane poet (*grāmya-kavi*) is painful; to hear the words of one who is expert and intimate (*vidagdha ātmīya*) is a joy.

108 Take the two dramas Rūpa has composed: on hearing their very opening, the prologue, one's joy increases."

109 Bhagavān Ācārya said, "Just hear it once. When you have heard it, you will be able to judge whether it is good or bad."

110 For two or three days the Ācārya pressed him, and at his insistence Svarūpa became willing to hear it.

111 Svarūpa Gosāñi sat down with everyone to listen, and the poet recited the *nāndī* verse, the opening benediction.

112 "He of golden luster who has here taken as His self the body (*ātman*) named Śrī Jagannātha, whose eyes are like blossoming lotuses, and who has appeared to enliven the whole of inert matter — may that Kṛṣṇa Caitanya-deva grant you good fortune."

113 Hearing the verse, everyone praised the poet, but Svarūpa said, "Explain this verse."

114 The poet said, "Jagannātha is the beautiful body, and Caitanya Gosāñi, most grave and steady, is the one embodied in it (*śarīrī*).

115 To bestow consciousness on the inert world, as is His nature, Mahāprabhu has appeared in Nīlācala."

116 Hearing this, everyone was delighted, but Svarūpa, deeply pained, spoke angry words:

117 “O fool, you have brought about your own utter ruin! You have no faith in either of the two Lords!

118 Lord Jagannātha is full of bliss, a form of pure spirit, yet you have made Him out to be an inert, perishable, material body!

119 Caitanya, full in all six opulences, is Svayam Bhagavān, the Supreme Lord Himself, yet you have made Him out to be a tiny *jīva*, like a spark!

120 For this offense against both you will meet a dire fate! When one ignorant of the truth describes the truth, this is his fate!

121 You have committed yet another great blunder (*pramāda*): by making a distinction between body and embodied in the Lord, you have committed an offense!

122 In the Lord there is never any difference between body and embodied. His own form (*svarūpa*) and His body are both spirit and bliss; there is no difference between them.

123 “This division of body and embodied never exists in the Lord.” (Kūrma Purāṇa)

124 “O Supreme Lord, I see nothing higher than this form of Yours, which is pure bliss, free of all difference, its radiance unobscured. You are the one creator of the universe, yet You are distinct from it, O Self, and You are the source of the elements and the senses. I have taken shelter of that form of Yours.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.3)

125 “O good of all the worlds, for our good You have shown this very form to us, Your worshippers, in meditation. We bow down to You, Bhagavān, whom those bound for hell, attached to false arguments, do not honour.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.4)

126 Where is Kṛṣṇa, full of bliss and opulence, the Great Lord (*Maheśvara*)? And where is the tiny, miserable *jīva*, a servant of *māyā*?

127 “The Lord, embraced by the hlādinī and saṁvit potencies, is eternal being, consciousness and bliss; the jīva, covered by its own ignorance, is a mine of countless miseries.” (words of Viṣṇusvāmī quoted by Śrīdhara Svāmī in his commentary on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.7.5–6)

128 Hearing this, the whole assembly was struck with wonder: “The Gosāñi speaks the truth! The poet has insulted both.”

129 On hearing this, the poet was filled with shame, fear and amazement. Like a heron among swans, he could say nothing.

130 Seeing his distress, the most merciful Svarūpa instructed him in a way that would bring him true good:

131 “Go and study the *Bhāgavata* from a Vaiṣṇava, and take exclusive shelter at the feet of Caitanya.

132 Always keep the company of Caitanya’s devotees; then you will come to know the waves of the ocean of *siddhānta*.

133 Then your learning will bear fruit, and you will describe Kṛṣṇa’s true nature and pastimes purely, without fault.

134 You composed this verse with great satisfaction, but by the meaning in your heart it attaches fault to both Lords.

135 You speak any which way, not knowing the proper method; yet with those very words Sarasvatī has offered praise.

136 Just as when Indra, the demons and others rebuke Kṛṣṇa, Sarasvatī offers praise with those very words.

137 “Taking shelter of Kṛṣṇa — a talkative, childish, stubborn, ignorant mortal who thinks Himself learned — these cowherds have offended me.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.25.5)

138 Indra, maddened by the intoxication of his opulence, was like a drunkard: his intelligence was lost, and he had no self-control at all.

139 Indra says, “I have reviled Kṛṣṇa,” yet from his very mouth Sarasvatī offers praise.

140 ‘*Vācāla*’ (talkative) means the glorious promulgator of the Vedas; ‘*bāliśa*’ (childish) — though great, He is like a child, free of pride.

141 Because there is no one for Him to honor, He bows to none: this is what the word ‘*stabdha*’ (stubborn) says. And He beyond whom there is no other knower is ‘*ajña*’ (ignorant) — there is nothing for Him to learn.

142 The one honored by the learned is ‘*paṇḍita-mānī*’; yet out of affection for His devotees He regards Himself as a human being, a ‘mortal’.

143 Jarāsandha said, “Kṛṣṇa is the lowest of men! I will not fight with You — go away, slayer of Your kinsmen!”

144 He in comparison with whom all other persons are lower is ‘*puruṣādhama*’ — that is Sarasvatī’s meaning.

145 Because it binds everyone, ignorance (*avidyā*) is the ‘*bandhu*’; so the word ‘*bandhu-han*’ means the destroyer of ignorance.

146 In the same way Śiśupāla reviled Kṛṣṇa, and with those very words Sarasvatī offered praise.

147 So too in this verse: by your meaning, blame comes forth. Now hear Sarasvatī's meaning, in which praise shines.

148 Jagannātha is Kṛṣṇa's very self (*ātma-svarūpa*), but here He is the Dāru-brahma, in an immobile form.

149 Being one in selfhood with Him, Kṛṣṇa, the one truth, has become two forms.

150 Uniting in that will (*icchā-śakti*) whose aim is to deliver souls from *saṁsāra*, They attain such oneness.

151 To deliver all the people of the world, He descended in the moving form of Gaura.

152 By seeing Jagannātha one is freed from *saṁsāra*, but not all the people of every land can come to Him.

153 So Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Prabhu, going from land to land as the moving Brahman (*jaṅgama-brahma*), delivered everyone.

154 This is the explanation I have given of Sarasvatī's meaning. It is your good fortune, too, that you described Them in this way.

155 One may utter Kṛṣṇa's name only to abuse Him, yet that very name becomes the cause of his liberation."

156 Then the poet fell at everyone's feet and, holding straw between his teeth, took shelter of them all.

157 Then all the devotees accepted him, and, speaking of his good qualities, introduced him to Mahāprabhu.

158 The poet gave up everything and remained in Nīlācala. Who can describe the mercy of Gaura's devotees?

159 Thus I have told the account of Pradyumna Miśra, who by the Lord's order heard talks about Kṛṣṇa.

160 Within it I have told the glory of Rāmānanda, the full extent of which the Lord Himself described with His own holy mouth.

161 In passing I have also told the account of the poet's drama: though ignorant, by faith he attained the Lord's feet.

162 The pastimes of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya are the essence of nectar: from the stream of a single pastime flow hundreds upon hundreds of currents.

163 Whoever reads or hears this pastime with faith comes to know the pastimes of Gaura, *bhakti*, the devotees and the truth of *rasa*.

164 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.